

1. The Scriptures:

“And to every beast of the earth, and to every bird of the air, and to everything that creeps on the earth, everything that has the breath of life, I have given every green plant for food.” And it was so.”

Source: Genesis 1:30

“Do not invite death by the error of your life, or bring on destruction by the works of your hands; because God did not make death, and he does not delight in the death of the living. For he created all things so that they might exist; the generative forces of the world are wholesome, and there is no destructive poison in them, and the dominion of Hades is not on earth. For righteousness is immortal. But the ungodly by their words and deeds summoned death; considering him a friend, they pined away and made a covenant with him, because they are fit to belong to his company.....for God created us for incorruption, and made us in the image of his own eternity, but through the devil's envy death entered the world, and those who belong to his company experience it.”

Source: Wisdom of Solomon 1:12-15, 2:23-24

2. Theophilus of Antioch:

"Thus, too, though such persons are called men, yet being pressed down with sins, they mind groveling and earthly things. And the animals are named wild beasts, from their being hunted, not as if they had been made evil or venomous from the first for nothing was made evil by God, but all things good, yea, very good but the sin in which man was concerned brought evil upon them. For when man transgressed, they also transgressed with him. For as, if the master of the house himself acts rightly, the domestics also of necessity conduct themselves well; but if the master sins, the servants also sin with him; so in like manner it came to pass, that in the case of man's sin, he being master, all that was subject to him sinned with him. When, therefore, man again shall have made his way back to his natural condition, and no longer does evil, those also shall be restored to their original gentleness."

Source: Theophilus of Antioch, To Autolycus, Book 2, Chapter 17

3. Irenaeus of Lyon:

"Wolves and lambs shall then browse together, and the lion shall eat straw like the ox, and the serpent earth as if it were bread; and they shall neither hurt nor annoy anything in my holy mountain, says the Lord. Isaiah 40:6, etc. I am quite aware that some persons endeavour to refer these words to the case of savage men, both of different nations and various habits, who come to believe, and when they have believed, act in harmony with the righteous. But although this is [true] now with regard to some men coming from various nations to the harmony of the faith, nevertheless in the resurrection of the just [the words shall also apply] to those animals mentioned. For also apply] to those animals mentioned. For God is rich in all things. And it is right that when **the creation is restored, all the animals should obey** and be in subjection to man, **and revert to the food originally given by God** (for they had been originally subjected in obedience to Adam), that is, **the productions of the earth.** But some other occasion, and not the present, is [to be sought] for showing that the lion shall [then] feed on straw. And this indicates the large size and rich quality of the fruits. For if that animal, the lion, feeds upon straw [at that period], of what a quality must the wheat itself be whose straw shall serve as suitable food for lions?"

Source: Irenaeus of Lyon, Against Heresies, Book 5, Chapter 33

4. Ephraim The Syrian:

“That [Moses] said, He brought them to Adam, is so that God might make known the wisdom of Adam and the harmony that existed between the animals and Adam before he transgressed the commandment. The animals came to Adam as to a loving shepherd. Without fear they passed before him in orderly fashion, by kinds and by species. They were neither afraid of him nor were they afraid of each other. A species of predatory animals would pass by with a species of animal that is preyed upon following safely right behind. Adam thus began his rule over the earth when he became lord over all on that day according to the blessing he was given. The word of the Creator came to pass in actuality and His blessing was indeed fulfilled on the same day that he was made ruler over everything, even though he would soon rebel against the Lord of everything. For God gave Adam not only rule over everything, which had been promised to him, but He also allowed him to bestow names [on the animals], which had not been promised to him.”

Source: Ephraim The Syrian, Selected Prose Works, Commentary on Genesis, Page 103

5. Basil The Great:

"Behold, I have given you every tree which has fruit in itself; it will be to you for food' [Gen 1.29]. Let the church not skip over anything. All things are prescriptive. It does not say, "I have given you the fishes for food. I have given you the domestic animals, the reptiles, the quadrupeds." For he did not create these things for this purpose, as Scripture says. But the first legislation granted enjoyment of fruits, for we were still reckoned to be worthy of paradise. And what is the mystery present for you in what is hidden here? To you, the wild beasts and the birds the fruits are given, it says, and the green plants and the grass. "For you as food, to the birds of the sky and all the wild beasts of the earth" [Cf. Gen 1.30]. Yet indeed we see many of the wild beasts do not eat fruit. With what fruit does the leopard accept to be nourished? And what fruit can feed a lion? But these animals in the same way, subjected to the law of nature, were sustained by fruits. But when the human being changed his habits and went outside the limit given him, after the flood, the Lord, knowing the humans to be profligate, granted them the enjoyment of all foods. "Eat all these things as you do green vegetables" [Gen9.3]. By this concession the rest of living beings also received the freedom to eat them. For this cause, the lion is a carnivore, for this cause also vultures await carcasses. For doubtless indeed vultures did not look around the earth when living things came to birth. For nothing died of these things given meaning or brought into existence by God, so that vultures might eat it. Nature was not divided, for it was in its prime; nor did hunters kill, for that was not yet the custom of human beings; nor did wild beasts claw prey, for they were not carnivores. And it is customary for vultures to feed on corpses, but since there were not yet corpses, not yet their stench, so there was not yet such food for vultures. But all followed the diet of swans and all grazed the meadows. And as we often see dogs grazing on grass for the sake of healing, not since it is the food natural to them, but since the nonrational animals by some teaching of nature come untaught upon what is useful, we also consider the carnivorous animals then [in paradise] to be such, to regard grass as their food, not plotting against each other."

Source: Basil The Great, Homily 2, On the Origins of Humanity, Discourse 2, Pages 52-53

6. John Chrysostom:

“But let us return to the question proposed before. It emerges, you know, from what we've said that the human being from the very beginning had complete control of the wild beasts; the text says, remember, "Let them have control of the fish of the sea and the birds of heaven, the wild beasts and the reptiles of the earth." The fact that now we have fear and dread of the wild animals and have lost control of them, I personally don't dispute, but this doesn't betray a false promise on God's part. **From the beginning, you see, things weren't like this;** instead, the wild beasts were in fear and trembling and responded to direction. **But when through disobedience human beings forfeited their position of trust, their control was also lost.** As evidence, after all, that everything was placed under the human being's control, listen to the Scripture saying, "All the brought the wild animals and all the brute beasts to Adam to see what he would call them." And seeing the animals near him, **he didn't shrink back,** but like a master giving names to slaves in his service, he gave them all names; the text says, "They each bore the name Adam gave them," this being a symbol of his dominion. Hence God was wanting to teach him through this the dignity of his authority, so he entrusted to him the giving of names.”

Source: John Chrysostom, commentary on Genesis, Page 121-122

7. Jacob of Sarug:

They grazed and were satisfied, the sound of herds was in the meadows of their master; **there was no harm done nor even hostility in any of these places.** New animals that the soil had produced filled the earth, they grazed and were satisfied on the fresh foodstuffs that were there.....Why was it necessary **to produce grass in the meadows of the earth, except that the beasts be satisfied by His gift.** As it is written, "He gives to the beasts their food", Ps 147:9, for His creatures continually receive their fill from Him.

Source: Jacob of Sarug, Homilies on Creation, The Sixth Day, Pages 26 and 30

8. Gregory Bar Hebraeus:

(4:1) "And she said, I have acquired a man to the Lord." That is, the name of Cain was derived from ("ownership"), and that of Abel from ("the gift of God"). And "to the Lord" she said; he is in truth the giver of offspring, but the male is an organ and an intermediary only. (2) "And Abel was a shepherd of sheep," i.e., inasmuch as **by the transgression of the commandment the carnivorous animals had dominion over them.** "And Cain was a husbandman in the earth," i.e., a cultivator. (4:3) "And Cain brought from the fruits of his land an offering to the Lord. (4) And Abel also brought from the first-born of his flock."

Source: Gregory Bar Hebraeus, Scholia on the Old Testament, Genesis, Pages 27 and 29